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The major change coming to food in California grocery stores under new law

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A major shake-up could be coming to grocery stores in California — and it might just help health-conscious shoppers.

In a new bill, California state has proposed a first-in-nation label that would warn consumers which foods are ultra-processed.

Under the plan, foods that are not ultra-processed — such as canned beans, yogurt and sauces made with few ingredients — would be able to apply for and carry a new label, 'California Certified,' that would signal they are not heavily processed. It would function in the same way as other labels, such as USDA Organic.

Grocery stores would also be required to place these approved products in prime locations, such as at the end of aisles, checkout lanes and store entrances.

There is no federal definition for ultra-processed, but California is using its own, which says a food is ultra-processed if it contains artificial flavors, colors, emulsifiers or stabilizers and is high in added sugar, sodium or fat.

The bill, dubbed AB2244, was introduced to California's House last month. If approved, legislators say the label would first be used in 2028.

It was proposed by Democrat Congressman Jesse Gabriel, who said: 'Parents shouldn't need a PhD in chemistry to understand what they're feeding their kids.

'Like the USDA Organic label, this new seal will empower consumers with clear, trustworthy information and make it easier for them to locate healthier foods that are free from harmful additives.

'While Washington DC is paralyzed by inaction, California is stepping up to protect our kids and confront the health risks associated with ultra-processed foods.'

It comes as the federal government prepares to publish its first-ever definition of ultra-processed foods next month.

Robert F Kennedy Jr, the Health and Human Services Secretary, has said he is also considering adding front-of-pack nutrition labels to products high in fats, salts and other nutrients.

About 55 percent of the calories that Americans consume daily are from ultra-processed foods, according to the CDC. Among children, 62 percent of their calories come from ultra-processed foods.

These foods are often hyperpalatable and easily digested. A growing body of research has linked them to chronic diseases, including obesity, cancer, heart disease, type 2 diabetes and metabolic problems.

So far, the bill has been read in California's House and is now set to be heard by the state's Health Committee in the coming months.

To become law, it will need to pass both California's House and Senate and then be signed by the Governor. Governor Gavin Newsom's term ends in January 2027.

Supporters of the bill hope it will prompt manufacturers to use fewer or natural ingredients in their products in order to get them approved for the label.

Foods likely to be considered ultra-processed in California include packaged breads, sodas and potato chips. Foods generally considered healthy, such as salad kits or dressings, can also have additives that make them ultra-processed.

Members of Congress in California argue that the bill will address widespread consumer confusion around nutrition labeling and ingredient lists. But representatives of food manufacturers say it will unfairly single out foods, arguing there is no definition for ultra-processed foods. They also say it could make nutrition overly complex.

The bill has already attracted celebrity support. Maria Menounos, a former TV host who backs the bill, said at a news conference this week: 'I know a lot of people will say, "Well, shop on the outside aisles," but not everybody's there yet.

'Until they get to that place, there are going to be things in the middle they're going to want.'

Gabriel, who proposed the bill, was also behind the California's 'Skittles ban,' which saw it become the first state in the nation to ban the use of certain food dyes.

The ban was passed in October 2023 and is set to come into force on January 1, 2027.

The federal government has also sought to pile pressure on businesses that use artificial colors. In October 2025, California also signed into law the nation's first-ever ban on ultra-processed foods being served in school meals.

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